THE SPONSOR'S PLAYBOOK

A GUIDE TO EFFECTIVE RECOMMENDATION AND ACTIVE SPONSORSHIP

"When women recommend women, incredible things happen."

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1. INTRODUCTION: Why Sponsorship Matters

You've received this playbook because you've taken the first step toward something powerful: **becoming an active sponsor for women's leadership.**

Perhaps you've already mentored brilliant women. You've given advice, shared insights, and watched them grow. But you've also noticed something: even the most talented women often wait too long to be invited, while others—less qualified but more visible—step into opportunities they deserve.

This is where sponsorship changes everything.

Mentorship is conversation. Sponsorship is action.

A mentor advises from the sidelines. A sponsor speaks your name in rooms you cannot enter. A mentor helps you prepare for the interview. A sponsor ensures you're on the shortlist.

This playbook will equip you to be that sponsor. To move from good intentions to intentional impact. To become the leader who doesn't just believe in women—but actively places them in seats of power.

Welcome to the movement.

2. WHAT IS A SPONSOR? (And How It's Different from a Mentor)

Many people use "mentor" and "sponsor" interchangeably. They are not the same—and understanding the difference is essential.

Mentor	Sponsor
Advises and guides	Advocates and acts
Provides feedback	Provides opportunities
Listens and counsels	Opens doors and makes introductions
Helps you grow in place	Helps you move up and out
Privately supports	Publicly champions
Relationship is often long-term	Relationship is often opportunity-driven

In short: A mentor helps you *develop*. A sponsor helps you *advance*. Both are valuable. But if you want to accelerate women into leadership, **sponsorship is the accelerator.**

3. THE SPONSOR'S MINDSET

Before you take action, adopt these four beliefs:

Mindset 1: Talent is everywhere; opportunity is not.

Your role is to bridge that gap. Brilliant women exist in every organization, every industry, every community. Your job is to find them and connect them.

Mindset 2: My network is not just for me.

The relationships you've built, the credibility you've earned, the doors that open for you—these are not just privileges. They are resources to be shared.

Mindset 3: Perfection is the enemy of progress.

Women often wait until they meet 100% of qualifications before applying. Sponsors look for 70% readiness and 100% potential. Trust your judgment.

Mindset 4: Sponsorship is not charity; it's strategy.

Diverse leadership produces better decisions, stronger innovation, and healthier organizations. By sponsoring women, you're not just being kind—you're being smart.

4. THE 4 PILLARS OF EFFECTIVE SPONSORSHIP

Every powerful sponsorship rests on four foundations:

Pillar 1: Visibility

Make her seen.

- Invite her to meetings she wouldn't normally attend
- Introduce her to your network
- Nominate her for projects, committees, and high-visibility roles
- Ensure her name is known to decision-makers

Pillar 2: Advocacy

Speak her name.

- Recommend her for promotions and opportunities
- Write strong, specific recommendations
- Correct misconceptions or biases when you hear them
- Champion her when she's not in the room

Pillar 3: Connection

Open your door.

- Facilitate introductions to key players
- Connect her with other sponsors and allies
- Bring her into professional communities

Pillar 4: Courage

Take a risk.

- Sponsor someone who doesn't look like you
- Recommend someone who isn't the "safe" choice
- Stand by her when she faces resistance

- Share intelligence about organizational culture and politics

- Use your capital to create space for her to lead

5. HOW TO IDENTIFY TALENT WORTH SPONSORING

Not every talented woman is ready for sponsorship. Not every ready woman has found her sponsor. Here's what to look for:

The 5 Qualities of Sponsor-Ready Talent

1. **Competence:** She delivers results. Her work speaks for itself.
2. **Character:** She is trusted by colleagues and leaders alike.
3. **Curiosity:** She asks questions, seeks feedback, and wants to grow.
4. **Courage:** She takes on challenges, even when uncertain.
5. **Contribution:** She lifts others as she rises.

Questions to Ask Yourself

- ✦ When I think of a project that needs to succeed, whose name comes to mind?
- ✦ Who consistently delivers more than expected?
- ✦ Who asks thoughtful questions in meetings?
- ✦ Who do colleagues respect and seek out?
- ✦ Who has potential beyond their current role?

Your answer to any of these questions could be your next sponsorship opportunity.

6. THE ART OF THE RECOMMENDATION

A recommendation is more than a LinkedIn endorsement. It's a strategic act of advocacy. Here's how to do it powerfully.

The 3 Types of Recommendations

Type	When to Use	Example
The Warm Introduction	When you know both parties would benefit	"I'd like you to meet [Name]. She's doing incredible work in [area] and I believe there's synergy with what you're building."
The Formal Nomination	For roles, awards, or programs	"I'm writing to nominate [Name] for [Role/Opportunity]. She has [specific strength] and I'm confident she would excel."
The Unsolicited Endorsement	When you hear an opportunity discussed	"You mentioned needing someone for [project]. Have you considered [Name]? She's exceptional at [skill]."

The Recommendation Formula

1. **Open with conviction:** "I'm writing to enthusiastically recommend..."
2. **State your relationship:** "I've worked with [Name] for [X years] as her [manager/colleague]."
3. **Highlight specific strengths:** "She excels at [specific skill], demonstrated when she [specific achievement]."
4. **Address potential:** "I believe she is ready for [next level/opportunity] because..."
5. **Close with confidence:** "I would entrust her with this opportunity without hesitation."

Sample Recommendation

"I'm writing to enthusiastically recommend Amina Diallo for the Senior Marketing Director role.

I've worked with Amina for four years as her manager, and she is one of the most strategic thinkers I've encountered. When she led our West Africa expansion, she developed a market entry strategy that exceeded revenue targets by 35% in the first year—despite operating with limited resources.

What sets Amina apart is her ability to combine creative vision with data-driven execution. She doesn't just propose ideas; she proves they work.

I believe she is ready for this senior role because she already operates at that level—mentoring junior team members, influencing cross-functional stakeholders, and representing our department in executive meetings.

I would entrust her with this opportunity without hesitation, and I'm confident she will exceed your expectations."

7. REAL-WORLD SCENARIOS: What Sponsorship Looks Like in Action

SCENARIO 1: THE PROMOTION OPPORTUNITY

Situation: A senior role opens in your organization. A talented woman on your team has the potential but lacks one qualification listed.

Sponsor Action:

- ✦ You advocate for her inclusion in the candidate pool
- ✦ You speak to the hiring manager: "She doesn't have X on paper, but she's demonstrated Y and Z, which are more relevant. I've seen her learn quickly. Don't let a checkbox exclude exceptional talent."
- ✦ You offer to support her transition into the role

SCENARIO 2: THE EXTERNAL CONNECTION

Situation: A contact in another organization mentions they're hiring for a role that would be perfect for a woman in your network.

Sponsor Action:

- ✦ You immediately connect them: "I know someone exceptional for this. Let me introduce you."
- ✦ You send a brief, powerful email highlighting her strengths
- ✦ You follow up with both parties after the introduction

SCENARIO 3: THE ROOM WHERE IT HAPPENS

Situation: An important meeting or event is happening, and your protégé isn't included.

Sponsor Action:

- ✦ You ask: "Should [Name] be in this meeting? Her perspective on [topic] would be valuable."
- ✦ If possible, you bring her as your guest
- ✦ You ensure she has context beforehand and debrief with her afterward

SCENARIO 4: THE UNFAIR CRITICISM

Situation: You hear someone dismiss or unfairly criticize a woman you sponsor.

Sponsor Action:

- ✦ You speak up: "I see it differently. Let me share what I've observed..."
- ✦ You provide specific examples that counter the criticism
- ✦ You pull the critic aside privately if public correction would be counterproductive
- ✦ You check in with your protégé afterward to offer support

8. YOUR SPONSORSHIP TOOLKIT

Use these tools to make sponsorship part of your regular practice.

Tool 1: The Sponsorship Pipeline

Keep a running list of women you're sponsoring or considering. Note:

- Name and role
- Key strengths
- Goals and aspirations
- Potential opportunities to recommend them
- Last action taken

Tool 2: The 30-Second Pitch

Prepare a concise, powerful statement about each woman you sponsor. You never know when 30 seconds with a decision-maker could change everything.

> **Template:** "I want you to know [Name]. She's a [current role] who [key strength]. She recently [specific achievement]. I believe she's ready for [next opportunity]."

Tool 3: The Introduction Email Template

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Subject: Introduction: [Name] / [Their Name]

Dear [Name 1] and [Name 2],

I've long believed that great things happen when great people
connect. That's why I'm introducing you to each other.
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[Name 1] is [brief description]. [Name 2] is [brief description]. I
see potential synergy in [specific area].

I'll let you take it from here, but I'm happy to provide more
context if helpful.

Warmly,
[Your Name]
```

Tool 4: The Sponsorship Check-In

Quarterly, ask yourself:

- Who have I sponsored recently?
- What doors have I opened?
- Whose name have I spoken in rooms they couldn't enter?
- Who am I overlooking?

9. THE SPONSOR'S COMMITMENT

As a **Recommend Her** sponsor, I commit to:

1. **See talent actively.** I will look beyond the usual places and notice women with potential.
2. **Speak names intentionally.** I will recommend qualified women when opportunities arise—even when no one asks.
3. **Open doors generously.** I will share my network, my credibility, and my influence.
4. **Take risks courageously.** I will champion women who don't fit the traditional mold.
5. **Stay engaged consistently.** Sponsorship is not a single act but an ongoing commitment.
6. **Hold myself accountable.** I will track my actions and seek feedback on my impact.
7. **Encourage other sponsors.** I will invite peers to join this movement and share what I've learned.

10. JOIN THE MOVEMENT

You now have the tools, the mindset, and the framework to become an effective sponsor. But tools without action change nothing.

Your next step:

1. **Identify one woman** you can sponsor—formally or informally—starting this week.
2. **Take one action:** Recommend her for something. Introduce her to someone. Speak her name in a room she cannot enter.
3. **Share your commitment** with the **Recommend Her** community. Tag us. Inspire others.
4. **Return to this playbook** regularly. Sponsorship is a practice, not a one-time event.

A Final Word

The world does not lack talented women. It lacks sponsors willing to recommend them.

You are now part of the solution. Every name you speak, every door you open, every risk you take on behalf of a woman with potential—these actions ripple outward, changing not just individual careers but the very face of leadership.

Thank you for being a sponsor. Thank you for being part of Recommend Her.

Now go. Recommend her.

With gratitude and anticipation,

Wahda Mbaraka
Founder, Recommend Her Movement

Recommend Her Movement

Mentor. Recommend. Elevate.

www.recommendher.africa

#RecommendHer #SponsorPlaybook #WomenInLeadership